Bait and Switch

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Mature

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Alternate Universe - Space, Science Fiction, Space Pirates, Space Combat, Spaceships, Drama, Angst, Denial, oh so much denial, Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), space flirting

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by Jezmatron

Summary

Morale needs boosting.

After Adora's great victory against the Imperial Horde, the rebels seek a moment of calm amidst the chaos. in that, Adora is tasked with sewing some chaos.

Meanwhile, our Valiant space captain wrestles with her demons as nefarious agendas advance around her.

Notes

What's this?

A year in and a new SCC?

MADNESS.

Chapter 1

Bow stared up at the strange, rocky edifice before him. It was smooth, but clearly inlaid with glowing blue veins, which criss-crossed across its surface in neat, clear lines. At various points, small circles marked each angle, each change in the direction of a line. For all the world, it reminded him of a circuit board, albeit made from stone. And the lines both sat in the stone and also floated *above* it, in a strange holographic projection. Except there was no clear source for it.

It was strange - a lot of their current hideout was like this. Corridors with odd angles and floors that looked more like paving than a station's plating. At one angle it looked like metal, at another more like stone. There were ducts that led to hidden service sections filled with glowing crystals arrayed like fuse-boxes.

He'd been crawling through them, trying to work it all out. His maintenance crews were as baffled as he was, but it all seemed to work, even fragmented as this part of the planet was. He reckoned there was some sort of backup or independent generator powering this area.

"Penny for your thoughts, Chief?" a cooing voice purred from nearby. Bow rolled his eyes and glanced behind him.

"Heyah DT. Just kinda *mesmerised*, y'know?"

The Tailor and apparent *secret spy person* smirked and strode forward to join bow, their pointed green ear flicking as they moved, "Careful, wifey dear may feel jealous. And while I've seen *many* things across this galaxy, I am unsure if I wish to see the lady who manages my tab getting *irked* by a wall. I feel it would wreck her self esteem."

DT plopped their elbow into the palm of their hand, then cocked their head at Bow, a bemused expression on their face as they gestured vaguely at the wall. The engineer chuckled, "It's so weird. I can't work out what's powering it., or if it's something embedded in the wall, or if it's drawing it in from the radiation of the planet. I mean, we're shielded, but it's drawing something from somewhere. It's keeping the lights on."

"And tall, blonde and broody hasn't helped?" DT's expression shifted ever so slightly. Bow snorted.

"Not so broody now. She's damn near belle of the ball! She was *drinking* yesterday. With TARA."

"Hmmm. I think she's turned a corner perhaps. I'll grant you that. But still…"

"She's helped get some of these things running. Honestly, she's tried but she doesn't quite understand the mechanics of it," Bow blew out a breath, then turned, "Coming? I need to swing by Perfuma's floor."

“Oh goody, are we getting fresh food soon? I am too pretty to subsist on those ration bars.”

“Yeah the grey ones are the *worst*.”

The pair moved through the blue-tinted corridors to an open platform that descended down. One part of the shaft was open to space with a crack in the facility’s wall. But a shimmering glow kept the vacuum at bay. It’d taken a while for the crew to realise they didn’t need enviro-suits on *permanently*. That said, Bow still had a tank on his hip and a mask ready.

Just in case.

The view of the green-black mist that surrounded the ruin of the planetoid vanished behind rock as the elevator found the next floor down. The pair meandered again until they reached a room that seemed more cave than room. The walls had been crushed in partially, giving the place a craggier feel where the smooth walls transitioned to darker rubble, or sheared surfaces.

The place was a riot of colour however and Bow let out a low whistle. The sound caused a woman with braided blonde hair to turn and regard them both with a beaming smile, “Bow! DT! Oh gosh, it’s lovely to see you both. I was about to update Angella, but I’m so pleased I can share some uplifting news. Look! That last batch of Sheaf seeds and Parapplena fruits have taken… and their growth is shocking!”

“Your fancy fingers at work, darling?” DT drawled with a smirk. Perfuma scoffed and rolled her eyes with a smirk of her own.

“Hardly. The hydroponics worked well enough but I was expecting weeks to get results, even with accelerant use. But Adora helped wire in some extra lights and showed me something she found which I believe was a remnant hydroponics unit and, well…” she gestured at the plants, “She advised that we may need to rotate plants out once harvested as it can put too much pressure on them and grant diminishing returns. But for getting things going, it's amazing.”

Bow blinked in surprise, “Wow. I’m... wow.” He ran a hand through his hair and shook his head, “Well, DT, looks like you’re getting some greens to go with the grey.”

“Joy,” sighed DT with a small smile. Perfuma shook her head.

“I’m surprised, no double entendre?”

“Grow me one and I’ll show you how to use it, darling. You both seem rather blasé about all of this though.”

Bow caught the concerned tilt of DT’s head and the tense way they held themselves. He shrugged, “Not much of a choice. We could try for a run from the system, but with the patrols, we have to make do. Angella is looking at options. Honestly, it’s amazing *but* I have to admit I’m not entirely comfortable relying on a

system I can barely wrap my mind around, or can't work out how to properly fix."

Perfuma shrugged, "I don't want to burden myself with worries and fears I cannot remedy. I will adapt with what I can, fix what I can and help others with what I have to hand. To waste my energy on delving too deep feels… wrong. And I trust Adora to tell me if something is a genuine risk."

DT shook their head, "Fine fine, both grand points. And I suppose Adora has earned the benefit of the doubt."

"Still scared of her?" Bow hid a small smile as he turned to look at a particularly interesting plant. DT rolled their eyes.

"With *reason* . And I know I cautioned against alienating her and championed her involvement… I am *worried* about the collateral now."

Bow shook his head as he walked along a row of plants, "I get it. But she's probably the main thing keeping us safe. You ok DT?"

The tailor huffed and flung their hands up, "Just… I'm cut off here. No traders, no excitement, just waiting. And I like a chillax as much as the next doll, y'know? But my goodness, where's the vim, the romance, the thrilllls?"

“Being in hiding from a psychotic navy doesn’t fill you with excitement?” Perfuma asked, genuinely curious. She folded her hands in front of her uniform, a green apron over a sort of dress-uniform, also green. DT hummed and glanced about for somewhere to possibly flounce dramatically. Finding nothing they crossed their arms.

“No. I just find myself lacking *motivation* .”

“Ah,” Bow said with a smile, “You’re bored. And you’re stirring things up to find entertainment?”

“Oh! You wound me Bow! Such accuracy…” DT smirked slyly, “Don’t tease me. But fine, yes, I’m bored.”

Perfuma clapped her hands and beamed, “A party! We need something to stir up spirits!”

Bow matched her and grinned, his own hands pumping the air for a moment, “Oh heck yes!”

“You can swear, darling, you know that?” DT sighed again, then looked thoughtful, “Actually… Why didn’t I think of this? Scratch that, all my idea, and you can’t prove otherwise. Ta ta, someone has to go be fantastic and organise a *soiree!”*

Perfuma and Bow watched the tailor go and shook their heads, before Bow looked at the new, stone-link hydroponics units, "So… can I have a look?"

—----------

Adora lay atop *Swiftwind*'s hull and gazed at the ceiling of the hangar. It was a rocky shelf rather than a roof, but you could still see the spiderweb of blue lines that had clearly marked this as a room of some sort at one stage. She wondered about that idly - had it been a hangar? Or some store room? Maybe a test chamber or a community hall? The ruins lacked so much in the way of actual markers or guidance. Occasionally in her delving she'd found places that could have been bunk rooms or apartments; places that seemed more for socialising or communal meeting areas. One had had the feel of a park, but she'd found it deep in a chunk of the planetoid, implying it had originally been buried under tonnes of earth, a sort of terrarium or garden space in a bunker. It made her wonder why they'd done that - had they essentially lived below ground so long they needed spaces like that? Or was it just because they wanted a beautiful space to break up the monotony of the halls.

The core buried in *Swiftwind* gave her no real answers. She *felt* things, that was for sure, but knowledge was a harder thing to put her finger on. Some of it was clearly from her implants, but they hadn't exactly cared about context. She was a vehicle for the system's deployment, or at least that had been the plan.

But now she was… free?

It was strange. So strange. She'd been denied her suit and felt that clawing dread of doom; Of the *end* . And then these people had rallied around her. Had helped her. Trusted her.

Ok that last one was a stretch, but she saw it in their eyes now.

But that wasn't the most confusing part. No. Not at all.

Catra.

Adora closed her eyes and sighed. It didn't hurt as much, not really. There wasn't a sense of muted anger, like she'd felt when she'd first seen the woman again. That Captain, who'd glowered as if nothing was wrong. As if *Adora* was in the wrong.

And then the victorious Captain, chasing down her… friends. Hounding them, cornering them.

And then the final girl. A woman with haunted eyes and a determined air.

Adora knew that look all too well - it'd been one she'd seen in the mirror since escaping her life as a Praetorian. Off the leash? Not quite. Feeling like she'd made a choice but was then hemmed in by that same choice?

Oh yes.

The blonde chewed her lip and let her vision unfocus. She was going to do something about it. She had to. She needed to stop Catra and whatever the Horde had planned. She knew it'd be *bad* considering how long they'd had *Swiftwind*.

But she knew she also had another objective. One she'd had all along, just with no easy target.

"Hey! You finished daydreaming?" Adora startled and shook her head, before she rolled over to glance over the side of *Swiftwind's* hull. All around the hangar ships were undergoing maintenance. Sparks flew as crews bolted on new armour; ammo crates clattered as weaponry was refilled and charged; and the hiss of cooling engines as ships came and went filled the air with a low hum. They were safe here, for now - as long as the patrols stayed close and didn't draw attention.

Adora focused on the smiling figure who stood next to her ship. Hands planted on the hips of her purple jump-suit, Glimmer smirked up at Adora. The blonde huffed, then swung her legs of the side of the ship, "Hey Glim."

"You will *never guess* what we're going to do next. Well, two things. First, mom wants to talk to you. And second… we're having a PARTY!"

“Uh…” Adora blinked owlishly, “What?”

“I knew you’d be excited!” Glimmer snorted, “Come on. It’s DT, got some hare-brained idea to get morale up. Not a bad one but they’re talking about some good news story stuff.”

Adora shook her head, then moved to clamber down the ladder built into *Swiftwind’s* hull, landing gently on the deck, “I mean, it makes sense. This place has been tense the past few days.”

“Duh. You landed a full on mecha in the landing bay while system wide communications went *ballistic* . I thought you were supposed to be all sneaky, Adora? Seems you went with the *punch stuff* solution.”

“The Horde… was not co-operating with my methods,” Adora harrumphed. Glimmer blinked and squinted at her.

“I am struggling to get used to the fact you can apparently *make jokes*. It’s… weird. But also kinda cool.”

“Oh I’m super funny. One time, in the academy, Catra and I…” she trailed off. Glimmer glanced at her and a small smile tugged at her lips, while it also warred with a hint of frustration.

“Go on. I don’t mind.”

Adora rubbed the back of her neck, "We, uh… we played a prank on some other cadets. We had this one absolute *asshole* in the dorm and we hid a ration bar in his mattress. The really smelly kind. He'd been picking on Catra and, uh, well… kept saying she smelled like a wet dog. So we did that and, every inspection, he'd get chewed out, until eventually the Force-Sergeant tore his mattress apart and all these mouldy ration bars fell out."

Glimmer blinked, "Uh huh."

"The Force-Sergeant just… stared. Like he couldn't work out what the hell was happening and this guy was just stood there gaping. And then I said, *"So that's where my bars went!"* and Catra just burst out laughing…"

Adora trailed off and Glimmer smiled awkwardly, "Ha… ha ha?"

The blonde let out a sigh, "You had to be there. Military humour doesn't translate well."

"Clearly," Glimmer deadpanned.

Their pair headed into the base proper, winding their way to the makeshift command room. Angella, Juliet and a few others stood around the room, monitoring their own information. Angella was mostly engrossed in a stack of data tablets. She glanced up from

her flimsy, temporary desk and nodded at the pair, "Adora. Thank you again for all this. I have to say again, I…"

Adora waved a hand, "Ma'am, no need. So, what's next?"

The Commander blew out her checks, then folded her hands demurely, "In short, supplies. We have what we need, to a point. But we're starving for intel beyond those communication taps we have, and our hydroponics won't be able to supply *everyone* . Without trade ships and resupply we're rather limited. So… I'd like to see if we can't grab some food. Especially since DT has insisted on a morale boosting event. I think it's needed and having supplies will help."

Adora grimaced, "And you think my vessel is best for this?"

Angella shook her head, "No. I think your vessel is best equipped to go harass Horde targets, so Mermista can go and liberate some supplies. It won't work for long before they realise you're a distraction, but we may be able to pull off a few hits."

Adora chuckled, "And when they do get wise to it, we can then actually hit the Horde somewhere hard."

The Commander's own smile widened, "Precisely."

“Alright, let me check the routes… we’ll want to avoid the ice planet for a while, buuut… I have some ideas.”

—--

Catra was, to not to put too fine a point on it, *brooding* .

She lounged in her ready-room, aboard the *Vengeance* , while Scorpia went through the duty checks. She felt *irked* , embarrassed and a little bit paranoid. Her XO turned and gave her a worried look, “All ok Wildcat?” she whispered.

The feline harrumphed, “Not really, Scorp. Getting… de ja vu. This all started with Adora handing us our asses… and now here we are again.”

“But! We have a Destroyer now?” Scorpia waved her claws, “Positive thinking!”

Catra rolled her eyes and clasped her hands behind her, beneath her cloak, “Small rewards. And now the Governor is looking for someone to blame.”

“But he thinks we’ve been infiltrated by a rival, right?”

“For now. And we need to keep it that way,” She sat up straighter and leaned on the desk, claws drumming against the metal, “And any updates on what Entrapta was working on?”

“She’s giving us summaries, but sounds like the Governor has locked down a lot of avenues. We’re getting the updates, but nothing technical… which I think I’m kind of grateful for?”

“Fair. But all I saw were mecha? Has she... copied Adora’s machine fully, like we planned?”

“Not sure.”

Catra grimaced, “We need that project. It’s a ticket to the core and to security, Scorpia. No more counter piracy, no more patrols. A seat at the table.”

Scorpia studied Catra and nodded slowly, “Just like you wanted, right Wildcat?”

Catra twitched and her tail lashed, “Exactly.”

Since Adora’s dramatic rescue of her ship, the fleet in system had been on edge. Increased patrols, a higher scrutiny of press-ganged transports and traders, longer sweeps. Governor Hordak had ensconced himself in the research base, after his teams had hardened it up. The place was a veritable fortress now - the

capital ship in orbit with its attendant fleet, battery-satellites with heavy weapons; planetary mass drivers aimed up at the sky.

Catra had requested the opportunity to 'reinforce the borders' and Hordak had eagerly dismissed her. Now she was wondering if that was a mistake.

Something else was also bothering her - Weaver was being uncharacteristically silent. Usually she'd chime in with some snide comment, but a lot was getting by. Catra glanced at the ceiling.

"Weaver, status update? Any new alerts?"

" *Nothing worthy of your esteemed attention,"* the voice had the usual sneering condescension. Catra sighed.

"So no sightings of the ship that had you so spooked, or the woman who did the same?"

The crackled of static over the speakers made it sound like Weaver was grinding non-existent teeth before she responded, " *Hardly. And curious why you are not more scared. But I believe we understand the rationale. Best take care, Commander, You cannot keep me in this box forever."*

"Eh, long enough is all I need, Weaver. Scorpia, the shackle protocols are still running right?"

“All hooked up and at full functionality, ma’am.”

“Fantastic,” Catra grinned and arched an eyebrow up at the speaker, “Thank you Weaver.”

Scorpia winced, then glanced at her tablet, “We have a supply convoy arriving in the system in seventeen hours. Should we do a surprise inspection?”

Catra shrugged and leaned back in her chair, mind a mess of uncertain ideas. She waved a hand and let out a sigh, “Make it so.”

Scorpia stood, saluted, and left the ready room. Catra massaged her temples and keyed the power to her terminal. She drummed her claws again, then cycled through to the files she’d managed to save and secure. Old, confidential mission logs that Entrapta had torn from Weaver’s shared memory.

Mostly redacted, they painted a bloody trail by her former friend. A story that didn’t match the girl she’d known. Or the girl she now knew floated out there in the black.

A nightmare existence that seemed to have run its course.

"Why didn't you run, Adora? Why?" She swallowed and tried out the lie, to see if she believed it this time, "And why didn't you *stay* ?"

Those last words felt bitter as she spat them out. But she could tell her dream was looming. If this project bore fruit, well, it was a meal ticket, riding on Hordak's tail-coats. She'd be a part of something greater, part of something powerful. She'd be feared. And maybe Adora would listen then?

Catra sat back in her chair as she keyed the power to her terminal off, hiding the distressing truth of things. She could ask Weaver about it, but the AI would lie or dissemble. Why bother when she had it in black and white.

With a breath, Catra smoothed her hair down, then slicked it back. The Governor preferred a more groomed look and, while she disliked it, it was necessary to make minor political capital. A scruffy look wouldn't endear the man.

Who knew, maybe she'd get lucky today. Maybe Adora would come and ask to join, ask to be part of things again?

Catra let out a sad laugh.

No, she needed to look to the future. To what would happen. To her own satisfaction, not the dreams of a child, clinging to old memories.

She scooped up her cap and secured it atop her head, then stepped from the ready-room to face another day.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Adora is the distraction, but maybe she's done TOO good of a job.

Sea Hawk has another crazy plan.

And Catra is Not Having Fun.

Chapter Notes

HURRAH! ANOTHER UPDATE.

Yeah, we're getting towards the mech fighting / Voltron monster fights soon. Let's see if Flogg does a good job. I am sure he will do amazingly well.

"What the hell *is that thing?"*

The bridge of the Horde patrol frigate was shrouded in red as alarms blared. The Captain bubbled in frustration, the dome of his water-filled environment suit gurgling as he shouted his demands across the bridge.

They were an hour out from the "liberated" fuel depot, heading for the new asteroid space station that Commander Catra had also seized. His eagerness to get in the good graces of the Governor by perhaps showing up this upstart new Commander was not going to plan. Their patrol route was through an empty pocket of space.

A couple of small vessels had popped up on their radar and he'd assumed it would be a simple shake-down.

The shaking of his vessel put the lie to that assumption.

"Captain Gorgle, The enemy vessel is secured to our hull. We can't.. .get a bead." The gunnery officer gripped at her console as the ship shook. On the command holograms the bridge crew could make out the vessel itself - some sort of cargo-hauler-mech. Gorgol vaguely remembered similar ones used in backwater logistical bases - some sort of transforming shuttle mech thing.

And one of them had ripped a turret off of his ship and was now beating at the hull.

"Where are our escorts?" he bubbled, his voice modulator barking out his translated commands in robotic, synthetic waves. An ensign at the comms terminal turned and shook his head.

"The corvettes are engaging the gunships Black One is reporting damage to their aft thrusters and that their top dorsal turret is offline. Black Two is in pursuit but every time it tries to move to engage the mecha it receives effective fire."

"Tell the lieutenants their priority is the safety of *our* vessel. If they're obedient we can swat the gunships for them. But if that damn mech destroys another turret…"

“Should we signal distress, sir?” the ensign asked.

“Are you insane, boy? That Catra witch would have us in the brig, the Governor would strip us of our ranks. Probably execute you all. No, we fight these idiots off. They just got luc-”

His words faded as the lights flickered. On the screen, the mech had jammed the turret *into* the hull and it was now steadily moving towards another turret that was trying to turn to aim at the walking ship.

A streak of automatic gunfire lanced across the hull of the frigate as one of the corvettes made a pass. The Captain growled, “Tell them to watch their fire! No use if they breach us too!”

The Ensign looked baffled, unsure how the corvettes could be expected to dislodge their attacker *without* close fire. The gunnery officer shook her head at him almost imperceptibly and he turned back to his console to relay the next set of contradictory orders.

Outside, Adora was having a *blast* . They’d stumbled upon a patrol, as planned and found it to be a potential challenge - two corvettes and a patrol frigate. This class had drones and the first thing she’d done was wreck the drone launch bay doors. No doubt the engineers were working on a way to override and release the annoying combatants. But the nature of her ship had allowed her to close the distance, feigning weakness as the Horde navy flexed their assumed authority.

When her ship had spun, transformed and landed on the frigate's hull, after blasting between the two corvettes, the Horde had clearly been stunned. A blast from her primary weaponry into the drone-bay doors had near-welded them closed. The arrival of Huntara and her gunships had ensured the corvettes were now being occupied.

And now she was happily whaling on the frigate. It gave her a chance to really see what the weaknesses of these ships were from the outside. She'd taken one down via sabotage, managed to damage more in the battle for the station, but in open combat with her restored *Swiftwind* she needed to be able to identify rapid strikes and weaknesses to take these ships out of the fray.

She'd disabled the drone bay and a turret, so now was walking across the ship to try to nail another emplacement. She paused, yanking back on the controls as tracer fire pinged across the hull.

"Careful blondie, you've got a fan club ."

"Thanks. Surprised they're still flying."

"Could say the same about that tub. Thought you were some sorta superweapon with that thing."

Adora snorted into her comms as she watched Huntara's gunship pursue the bulky corvette. The Horde corvettes looked like arrow-heads, with blister canopies on their "wings", and a large compartment down the spine. They were bulky and relatively slow, but had plenty of nasty weapons, mostly for small to medium target engagements. They were intended as picket ships, meant to be a pain for fighters and to pose a threat to smaller warships too. You often saw them as the leads of fighter wings, mini command ships as border fleets, or counter piracy.

Horde doctrine went with a two or three to one ratio of "escort" to "primary" vessel in warfighting. Solo ships, like Catra's had been, were an oddity, or usually part of a scouting in-depth campaign.

Local fleet commanders mixed things up, of course, but baseline doctrine meant that you'd see three escort frigates to one artillery one, normally, and two or three corvettes to a frigate, then fighters and so forth. The carrier group the Governor had brought had clearly an irregular force composition as these were the first corvettes Adora had seen so far. Considering this was the edges of the Empire and that most of these ships here seemed to be dog eared older stock, or repurposed logistical fleets, she wasn't *that* surprised. Clearly more ships were flooding in as the potentially lucrative opportunity of the destroyed planetoid had been noticed by the Governor.

Thoughts of Catra distracted Adora briefly and she cursed as she realised the frigate's turret had rotated. She managed to move her ship, shockingly agile for something of its design, far more so than the design specs should have allowed for.

The blast from the heavy plasma turret slid past her through the void and Adora winced as the sensors in *Swiftwind's* cockpit flashed a dangerous red, the emergency shielding flaring at the proximity to the glowing green heat.

With an adjustment of the pedals at her feet and a twist on the yoke, Adora powered her ship forwards, bringing a mechanised fist around. A blue glow surrounded the limb as the ship's core fed its strange power into the blow.

With a yell, Adora ploughed *Swiftwind's* fist into the armour of the turret, at the point where the barrel entered the dome. Blue energy fleshed and the armour of the Horde turret gave way, the mecha's arm embedded inside. Adora growled and pulled the trigger on her flight yoke, the weapons on *Switwind's* arm unfurling and firing *inside* the turret, before she yanked back.

Rounds of heavy solid-state ammunition ricocheted within the turret, shredding the electronics and mechanics with. Adora moved and pushed off the hull, blasting away as the turret fizzed, then detonated. The frigate lurched and spun. Adora watched its thrusters fire to try to correct, while the vessel also tried to spin to bring another weapon system to bear.

It felt like she was toying with them, but Adora needed to learn. And, frankly, she felt she needed some fun. Likely as not, she'd leave the vessel crippled - force the Horde to do a recovery. A destroyed vessel would result in a salvage job, and the Horde tended to treat that as lower priority; they were ruthless, but not entirely stupid. A vessel that was crippled and had crew, in this part of space, would mean they'd devote more time to it. If the ship was destroyed, there was no real point save to maybe gather

scrap and salvage and reinforce elsewhere. A crippled ship was a ship that could, *possibly* , be captured by an enemy and repurposed.

With a gleeful grin, Adora redirected her focus to the engines. She had some *learning* to do.

—----------

“Seems a bit easy, oh light of my life?”

Mermista, former captain of the *Seagate,* leaned back in her command chair. She was aboard the repurposed cargo hauler that now served as her new flagship of what remained of her crew and fleet. She turned an arch look that managed to convey mild irritation to her subordinate. The fact that her left hand had a soft grip of his sleeve, as if to anchor him close to her, was entirely incidental and not at all relevant.

“Duh. It’s the Horde. They *are* easy.”

Sea Hawk smiled down at her, his expression full of sickening adoration. She scoffed and looked away, though a blush tinged her dark skin. Her paramour chuckled and spoke quietly, a strange departure from his usual buoyant self, “True. except when they aren’t. It’s twelve auto-cargo ships and two corvettes, plus fighters? Seems a bit light?”

Mermista sighed and pulled him closer, “So, you think we run?”

Sea Hawk’s smile broadened, “Oh no. I say we make it *harder.”*

She blinked at him and rolled her eyes, “Of course. And how are we going to do that?”

“We steal the *whole convoy* .”

This time her blinking felt longer as her brain tried to process that. Their intent had been to disrupt the transports, knock one out, grabe a few dropped containers, then to book it out of there. Supplies enough to tide them over, allow them to strike some more shipments, quick and fast. But she knew that that would eventually lead to the horde consolidating their shipments and bolstering security - long term it was a bad idea.

This felt… worse?

“This feels worse,” she deadpanned, “Like, the Horde is going to NOTICE. And be able to track twelve cargo ships just flying to the nebula.”

“AU CONTRAIRE!” Sea Hawk’s voice was booming this time and several of the motley crew turned at their haphazard stations to

stare curiously at their XO, "We use… *deception* and *confusion* ."

"Yeah, well it's working on me. I hope your plan doesn't involve setting a ship to self-destruct and flying it at the fleet…?"

Sea Hawk mused and wagged a finger, "A fair accusation and… one I had considered, *but!"* he held a hand up, the sleeves of his rolled up blue jerkin flapping as he placated a scowling Mermista, "I thought we needed cargo intact. So, plan B, which was plan A until I did entertain the idea of a glorious set of fireworks, is we get in there and... reroute them."

Mermista blinked, then frowned, "Uh, that sounds… too easy?"

"HARDLY! But DT has decided we must celebrate, and our grand stories need delicacies and joys in equal measure! So, we'll steal all their stuff. Thumb our noses at the cowardly thugs!"

"I'm not hearing a *how* , here… babe." Mermista deployed the pet name as effectively as a laser guided torpedo. Sea Hawk blinked and beamed, his heroic pose shifting to one of glee. He shook his head and coughed.

"Well… captain. It's simple. Adora gave me the idea, really. We need to get close and identify the primary vessel - it'll have the destination and the others, while having similar, will actually just be following *that* ship. Their destinations are in there in case the lead ship is destroyed or disabled. Then they'll continue on. The

reason they don't *all* do it is because then you get an absolute ship-crash as they all try to arrive at the same time on similar routes. Saw that once in Klendagon, nasty, fifty drone ships all trying to fit in one docking bay, took weeks for them to unseal it all… packed in like…"

"Focus!"

"Ah, yes, sorry dear. Anyway, using the lead ship, we can then send dummy routes to the *others* and voila, instant dispersal."

"Routes?"

"Of course! Don't want them all going to the same spot. We can direct the rest of the fleet to head to their new destinations, strip them out, then scuttle them."

Mermista blinked *again* , "That is a scarily well thought out plan. But who can manage that?"

"I have been known to dabble in navigation systems in my time as a Captain," Sea Hawk brushed his nails against his tunic. Mermista's face went slack.

"No," Sea Hawk opened his mouth.

A buzz from the comm on her chair made Mermista pause. She keyed it and spoke, “Bridge, go ahead.”

Bow’s smooth, confident voice floated through the tinny speakers, *“Captain, engine’s running well, though seeing some spikes here and there, think it’s sensors drawing heavily, may want to dial down the gain, means you’ll be broadcasting as much as seeing.”*

Mermista and Sea Hawk exchanged a glance then looked back at the comm. Mermista nodded to herself slowly before speaking, “Bow, can you come up to the bridge?”

The man had joined them due to the rather temperamental nature of the vessels. He was a last minute addition, after Angella had laid out the plan - a safe assumption that technical knowledge would likely be required *somewhere* in the plan. And lo and behold here they were. Sea Hawk heaved a sigh and turned as the chief engineer for the whole of their little resistance ducked through the hatch onto the bridge.

“Hey, so… what’s the plan… woah that’s a lot of ships.”

Mermista regarded her temporary crewman. He was a wonder, having gotten most of the ships functional or repaired, with his crew. And he hadn’t needed much persuading to join this little jaunt. She smiled at him, “So, we need a favour. How’s your space walking?”

—----------

“Ma’am we have a priority message from the frigate *Lionfish* . They have been engaged by resistance forces.”

Catra leaned forward in her command chair and frowned. They were a few hours out from the solar system’s edge, due to meet with the incoming freighters. So far they had seen nothing untoward.

“A frigate? Solo?” she asked. The ensign nodded and Catra’s frown deepened. She looked at Scorpia who shrugged.

“I don’t know. Pirates?”

“Captain Gorgle is claiming it’s a surprise attack.”

The name was unfamiliar - one of the new Captains brought in by the Governor. Not one of his lackey’s but someone who was a threat. Catra drummed her claws on the arm of the command chair, “Any other vessels nearby?”

“None, ma’am. Governor has moved the bulk of the fleet into orbit of the ice planet. The *Lionfish* is between the refueling point and the main station. But on an oblique patrol route, so he’s close to us apparently…”

Catra sighed, feeling some sympathy for the beleaguered captain, but not much. The Horde didn't look kindly on failure, except with *good* reason. She gestured vaguely, "Redirect one of our escort frigates to answer, along with a corvette."

"Sorry ma'am, hold on.. .getting a visual…" the ensign winced as they interrupted.

The holo-display on the Destroyer's bridge lit up and Catra immediately stiffened.

It was a view from a gun cam on a corvette, which was trying to deal with a nippy formerly-Horde gunship. The same one stolen from *this* Destroyer. But that wasn't what drew her gaze. No, it was the white-gold cargo hauler that seemed to be trying to *punch* the frigate to death.

Catra's chest tightened. She wanted to snort a laugh, she wanted to scream. She wanted to bark orders and oddly, she wanted to cheer Adora's simple, idiot, bravado fuelled approach. But her duty crawled at the back of her head - she needed to recapture that ship. Maybe… maybe arriving with a Destroyer would chase Adora off, really show her how outmatched she was?

"Set a course, adjust heading to intercept. Order the corvettes escorting the *Lionfish* to focus on that vessel, keep it distracted. Helm, initiate emergency jump, in system."

"Belay that order. Authorisation Hordak-One." Weaver's cold voice chimed in. Catra bristled.

"Weaver…"

" *I am sorry Captain, I must countermand you, by order of the Governor - recent standing orders state any engagement with the known Praetorian and the weapon system they have purloined is to be handled by the Governor's own taskforce. My hands are tied."*

The AI's voice carried a honeyed sneer with it. Catra's fist clenched on the armrest and she could feel the metal and cloth tear under her claws.

"We should still move to support."

" *I am afraid that should you do that, I will have to intervene as it would put YOUR life at risk. And as you know, you have said I am unable to harm you… and by extension, I shouldn't let you come to harm either, correct?"*

That drew Catra up short, "What…?"

" *Anyway, I feel there are other matters that require your attention* ."

"Ma'am, convoy escorts are reporting pirate attacks on their vessels! The supply convoy is under attack."

Catra's tail lashed and she swore, "Adora's providing a distraction. Of course."

Scorpia clacked her claws nervously, "What?"

The Commander gestured, "She's taking her time beating up a frigate with her bare hands… and a convoy gets hit *right* at the edge of the system? Wonder what the priority could be…?" Catra's voice was all snark. She growled in frustration and sat back. She knew that if she interfered there'd be hell to pay. She couldn't help Adora, not that she would, of course. But she wasn't sure she'd be able to shoot her down. Or capture her.

Not knowing what she knew now.

Given time, maybe she could persuade her, but she needed time and a place to actually *talk* . No chance of that happening.

With disgusted hiss, Catra waved at the helm, "Continue on course to the convoy, best speed. At the earliest, emergency jump."

“For a clear jump to the edge of the system, it’ll be forty three minutes to ensure a clear direct route.”

“Make it so,” grumbled Catra as she slumped back into her chair. Her tail swayed and she worried.

For herself.

And for Adora.

—----------

Across the system, several thousand metres away from the *Lionfish* , a cylindrical pod slammed out of jumpspace. It drifted in the dark before flashing lights blinked in a ring at one end. A moment later, gas escaped as the cylinder split down the sides, coming apart. A shape uncoiled from within, bulky and jerky in its motion. Segmented tendrils clack from behind it, as its bidepal form stiffly unfolded into an upright position. A pair of engines glowed to life on the thing’s back as the Horde mech suit vibrated to life. Green and red lines flashed dimly across several points as the machine pivoted in the void.

Long arms, ending with sharp manipulators extended out from a boxy cockpit / torse composite. Four additional manipulators emerged from the machine’s back, above the stubby engine ports,

while the digitigrade legs moved to angle another set of engines. It reached into the drifting cylinder and pulled out a long weapon from within, more of a tank gun than a rifle at the scale it was.

Within, the pilot flexed his hands on the controls. Sweat beaded as the unfamiliar energy pulsed within the machine and he wiped a hand across his forehead, studying the red controls.

"Lieutentant Flogg, on site. Target acquired."

Hordak's cold voice slid through the comms, *"Good. Disable if possible. Eliminate if necessary. Ensure all recorders are active. Secondary units are on standby. Ensure they are not required, Lieutenant."*

Flogg swallowed, "Aye, sir."

A screen popped up, showing the gun-cam for his external weapon. Across the void, he sighted at the strange, bulky mecha that was brutalising the Horde Frigate.

"I have you now…"

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Adora duels in the void, while Bow takes on a rather ambitious task.

Chapter Notes

The chapter length has gone up by one.

Shush. Not like I have EVERY done that before. But I promise it'll be a quick 4th one after this!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“This is such a terrible idea,” moaned Bow as he clung to the side of a small shuttle-craft as it blasted through the black void. His comm crackled as Sea Hawk’s boisterous laugh echoed through his helmet speakers.

“But the daring, the danger, the DRAMA of it! What an adventure to recount to your lady love. There is swooning in your future, my friend.”

“There’s a high chance of her wrath is what you mean,” Bow retorted, his teeth clenching as the shuttle dove down towards the scattered convoy. In interstellar terms they were very close, a kilometre or two at most, but from here they looked like a snaking cluster of ships.

“Ah, well, no risk, no reward. Her relief will SURELY overpower her rage,” offered the possibly insane pirate-commander. He paused,

“Right?”

Bow actually smiled for a moment, “Well, hope is a thing… are we go..?”

He was interrupted by a flash as a score of fighter craft screamed across the void, a group on each flank, while Mermista’s motley collection of “frigate” level ships ploughed forwards from behind and to the aft of the convoy. The reaction was immediate as the Horde escort scrambled. The ten horde fighter craft were joined by drones that launched from the cargo ships and corvettes. Bow’s lips pursed and he grimaced. He definitely needed to override the cargo haulers then, if only to remove the drones as a force multiplier.

As the battle joined at the periphery of the convoy, the shuttle dove in, its sensor ping masked by the confusion of the battle. The pilot killed the engines as Bow used a portable terminal to try to ID the lead vessel, cursing as his magneting clamps wobbled against the hull every time the shuttle jinked around another hauler. He scowled at his screen as Sea Hawk queried, with only a *faint* sense of nerves, “Any time now, my friend.”

“There! Third from the lead.”

“ *Copy that, we have a bogey!”* the pilot reported. Bow swore and leaned out, spotting a drone that had locked onto their tail. The squat, oval-like thing let out a burst of tracer fire that went wide and Bow shook as he realised how completely vulnerable he was.

Another round of fire skittered across the top of the shuttle's hull, ricochetting off the armour. Bow shook as she began to fiddle with his tracker-pad and managed to identify a frequency. Desperately he flicked through some pre-made command prompts and applied them, before transmitting them in a cone behind the shuttle. His pad was using the shuttle's comms array, so the signal was boosted. Behind them the drone vibrated, then spun and dove into the side of one of the cargo drones, detonating violently. The cargo ship itself, a huge beige hauler, barely even shifted, even with one of its many containers now sporting a blast smear.

"Nicely done!" came Sea Hawk's crowing voice over the comm, "And I think you confused the heck out of a few more."

Indeed a few of the drones further out seemed to have gone a bit off target, firing blindly into the vid as they flew in erratic patterns. Bow winced, knowing what that meant.

"We need to move fast; they'll know something's jammed them so they'll look for a signal. I can't pull that trick again or they'll notice and be able to trace it back."

"Any chance they can do that now?"

"Doubtful? The pilots in the fighters likely can't spare the attention, but I bet those corvettes have a sensor suite so they'll be looking for bursts now."

The shuttle coasted to above the third cargo hauler and Bow disengaged his mag-locks, using his suit thrusters to descend to the ship. Sea Hawk joined him, waving the shuttle off as soon as they were secure. The ship blasted away, angling to join the dogfight nearby. Bow grunted as they started the trek up the spine of the ship towards a dome-like structure: the signal transmitter. The haulers were little more than a spine to support the myriad containers bolted to them, with a set of engines at one end and a bulky array at the front for sensors, with a surrounding cluster of sensors and transmitter masts. They weren't freighters, more auxiliary "truck trailers" that ran by themselves, great for routine routes. But not so great if they ran into issues, hence the need for an escort. The lack of any larger vessels showed the Horde was either deprioritising this route *or* (more likely, Bow thought) they just assumed no one would dare challenge them in a conquered territory.

"Ok, let's start cutting," Sea Hawk muttered. They could see a few access panels, which'd let them hardwire in. These things were mostly controlled via remote route allocation, but you needed codes and permissions and all the Horde bureaucracy just to get the damn thing to turn on. A hardwire would bypass that. And that was so unlikely, given the absolute insanity that doing an EVA during a hostile action that most military minds scoffed at it. Especially Horde military minds that only thought in terms of grand fleet engagements and overwhelming odds.

Bow was oddly grateful for that. And he hoped that the *other* types of minds in the Horde hadn't designed countermeasures to make up for the hubris of the majority of their leadership.

He mag-locked his pad to the side of the hatch and let it do a surface scan, which showed there was at least a pressure alarm, but mostly for registering impacts, to alert for damage, not intrusion. That was easily overridden at this range by spoofing and *ok* to it after carefully aligning his pad's sensors, "Ok, we'll need to get to the wiring inside so I can loop the alert signal to itself. We'll have maybe ten seconds to do that and… yeah I can see where it is. Then we need to get inside. Safer there at least."

"I am very much in favour of that plan," murmured Sea Hawk as he gazed around at the firefight that was inching *into* the convoy as the Horde tried to use the cargo ships as cover, relying on the durability of the huge ships. So far, it was mostly behind them, but some of the fighters seemed to be heading to the fore of the convoy to grab some breathing space. And that meant the rebels were chasing them. And they kept moving.

Not ideal.

"Well, best I get started…" Bow set to it.

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The flare of *Swiftwind's* energy core from blue to red was the only warning Adora got. She was manipulating a control arm to drive another punch into the frigate's armoured hull, but the flash and a twist in her gut as her ship *told* her something made her slam her feet down on the control pedals that controlled *Switwind's* mech legs.

That was why the supersonic round glanced across her hull rather than into her flank. The shot sent *Swiftwind* tumbling off the hull of the frigate and she struggled to right herself, keying the comms as she did so, "Tara! We've got a bogey, any sign of another capital ship?"

"Negative, we had a heat bloom but can't pinpoint. Nothing on sensors," came the growled reply. Adora cursed and boosted back towards the frigate. She worked out the trajectory, given the round strike, her angle of ejection, but her sensors showed nothing in the direction she panned *Swiftwind's* scanners.

"If it's more of those damn squid drones I am going to be… annoyed," fumed the blonde. She boosted towards the frigate, when the screens flashed once more. This time she reversed course,and she barely saw the round flash mere inches in front of her vessel - a bank to the side would have meant a glancing blow, but still a fairly nasty one, "Ohhh sneaky. Predictive targeting."

Adora's eyes narrowed and she flipped her ship forwards again, jinking at odd angles and speeds, before she jetted away from the frigate. She angled away then around, using the opportunity to blast towards one of the escort corvettes. Her eyes narrowed and a grim smile briefly flashed across her face as, once more, her screen flickered. *Swiftwind* seemed to barely sense the threat, some form of targeting. Maybe she was being lased? Or a ping of some sort, a signal that locked onto *Swiftwind's* particular frequencies? Stars knew the Horde had enough data on her ship.

She buzzed away as a round split the space between her and the corvette. Except this round detonated, sending a wave of energy out. It crackled harmlessly against *Swiftwind's* shielding, fritzing her scanners for a moment. The gunship of one of her allies wasn't so fortunate as it lost power. Admittedly the corvette *also* lost power, but it was more likely to recover, given it had a better reactor, was larger and had more crew.

Adora chose. She dove towards the gunship and her mech's arms grappled to one of the pintle-arms that held one of the many cannons, before she boosted away. A curse across the radio clued her in that she had been half right.

"Tara?"

"Something just blew my starboard engine pod. Half power and the damn corvette is angling to get an effective lock. It's got no dorsal turret but…"

"Hang in there. Interloper 2, how's things?"

The pilot of the gunship cradled in *Swiftwind's* grip grunted over the comm, " *Generator is reigniting. Maybe 30 seconds, but it seems our sensors are still screwed: build up of static. We'll have to restart."*

"All right. Tara, get your people out of here. I'll buy you the time."

"Adora, that's a frigate, corvettes and something else…"

"I know. So many targets, I can't miss!" Adora's grin was cocky, confident and fuelled by an excitement she hadn't felt in a while, "I'm moving in on your pursuer. Good job you took out their fighter screen. Use the corvette, get in *close* ."

"Yeah. Great. "

Adora jinked and zipped, conscious that the unknown enemy hadn't lined up another shot. Likely they were going to try something soon as they worked her flight pattern out. So she did the unexpected. Her ship began to barrel roll, while the gunship pilot yelped in surprise.

Then she stopped and punted the gunship *towards* the corvette pursuing Tara. The pilot clued in rapidly and opened fire, rounds sparking along the corvette's flank. The larger ship, pursuing Tara, was in the process of rolling to bring a turret to bear but had to readjust, trying to now target the two closing clearer threats. Tara pivoted her own gunship, her remaining engine flaring, as she practically flipped her ship to charge the now utterly confused corvette.

Adora's hud flickered and she jinked, another round glancing over her hull. The shot sent her off course and allowed the corvette a chance to unleash a burst of fire at her. She cursed as a warning blared in the cockpit, indicating more immediate damage.

She needed to find this absolute pain in her rear. And she needed to get Tara and her team clear. She knew how snipers worked: they would wound enemy combatants to lure their comrades out. Right now, her allies were likely more a hindrance than a help.

She watched as the two gunships managed to rake the corvette with fire, moving into its shadow on the opposite side to the source of the apparent fire. After their strafing run, the pair of ships turned and made to burn for the edge of the combat zone. Now all Adora had to do was play the sniper at their own game.

She blasted towards the smoking corvette, noting that the second one was powering back up. She dove in and *Swiftwind* 's power core glowed behind her, within the recess of her cramped cabin, as she powered up the glowing blades at the end of her mech's arms. She jinked again, tanking a shot to one of the mech's legs as she applied a burst of speed. Warning lights flared but she ignored them as she plunged a blade into the flank of the corvette.

Swiftwind slowed as the blade caught, but not by much. She left a trailing red glow of melted steel and venting atmosphere as she drew a gouge in the side of the ship, including one of the turrets, before she accelerated away, charging towards the second corvette.

Behind her, the crippled ship flamed as escape pods jettisoned and the ship ruptured. Secondary explosions lit within as ammunition magazines and power cores overloaded.

The explosion framed her mech as she zipped towards the second corvette which seemed to be trying to manoeuvre closer to the near-crippled frigate, hoping to combine fire with the remaining ship and their mysterious ally. It was a cone of fire that met her, rounds tracing a line of lead in space.

But Adora wasn't really paying attention to that, letting her ship's fairly advanced computer perform its own evasive moves on the anti-ship fire. Instead she watched the black and the screens, waiting.

She caught it - barely there at all. A star flickered momentarily, beyond the frigate and her HUD flashed red.

Immediately, *Swiftwind* pivoted away and barreled towards the mysterious movement in the distance. Adora folded her mech into shuttle mode as she spiralled, granting her ship a boost in speed. She could barely see it, a smudge of black in the black. Her mouth ran dry as she managed to get a glimpse of the silhouette:

Another mech.

Something inside *Swiftwind* thrummed in what felt like anger. Which wasn't possible, given it was just a technical component. Adora twitched and angled away, the sudden shot barely missing her ship. Sweat poured down the back of her neck as she moved the controls, relying on her reactions and *Swifty's* strange intuition to avoid the incoming shots.

It didn’t quite work, as a round slammed into the forward port wind and sent her ship into a tumble. The controls flashed alarmingly as alerts blared. She saw the strange, dark mech move, repositioning as thrusters flared along its back. It moved fast, but not as fast as a fighter craft, and not as nimble either. It moved like a scaled up person in an EVA suit.

Interesting.

With a grunt, Adora righted her craft’s tumble before gunning the thrusters in a random direction. A blare of a proximity alarm showed she’d been narrowly missed again. With a hiss that was darn close to a chuckle, she blasted around, angling towards the corvette and the frigate, a plan forming in her head. It was a dumb plan, but she needed any plan rather than chasing a damn ghost. It was ironic, given how she normally operated.

Fire poured towards her and she moved, using the curtain of fire as a shield, albeit an imperfect one. Her ship flared as she shunted into mech mode, slowing and tumbling as if hit. She pulled her helmet up and even let some atmosphere vent from the ship as she let it power down a little. Now she just had to hope it was a capture and not a kill order. She reckoned she could take *one* hit… if needed.

She hoped.

—----------

“Target disabled,” growled Flogg as he moved his vessel to a new position. He was breathing heavily, shocked at how quickly this odd, little industrial mech had identified him and begun a charge. He’d gotten five shots off and only one had hit, in that charge, with an additional half dozen shots not landing cleanly. It was rather alarming.

He watched the ship drift. His instincts told him to take another shot, a killing blow. His HUD had the railgun lined up, ready and his hand gripped the flight control, finger over the trigger.

“Cover and allow for retrieval. Do not fire unless you detect movement .” came Hordak’s voice over the comm.

“Sir, I believe the target still has the potential for action,” protested Flogg. There was silence over the comm for a moment, before the Governor replied thoughtfully.

“Weaver, do you concur?”

“There is a high likelihood of subterfuge. The pilot is a potential Praetorian.”

Flogg twitched. That sealed it. He saw the remaining corvette closing in, intent to secure the downed ship and cursed. He made a call.

The railgun flashed.

The round connected, he knew it did. But the flash of blue energy from the supposedly downed mech blinded his sensors for a moment. He couldn't get a visual, even with multiple frequencies on his sensors.

The ship moved fast. It went from a drifting derelict to a weapon. Even with a direct hit, it didn't slow. The next time he saw it, it was beyond the corvette, which now trailed smoke as it spun in the void. His targeting system indicated that the ship had suffered impact damage and looked to have had one of its weapons torn completely clear.

He saw the enemy mech blast to the frigate which feebly tried to fire on it, before it vanished around the bigger ship's flank. Flogg cursed and shook his head as Hordak's voice came back over the comm, " *Status* ?"

"Target was not downed. Took a direct hit to the centre mass. Estimate hull damage but the vessel is still effective. Allied ships neutralised, I have lost signal for the enemy gunships."

"They are irrelevant. Move to eliminate the enemy. Capture is no longer feasible given positioning of assets. Do not miss again."

Flogg's face set in a grim smile, his purple skin twisting with the expression. He gunned the thrusters drifting to flank the frigate, power still low and sensors tuned high. His comm crackled as the crippled frigate sent out another mayday. He ignored it but the transmission was ongoing. He flicked to their frequency and frowned.

"It's cutting us apart! It's in the ship! It's in the damn ship! We're abandoning ship and scuttling! Mayday mayday! Hostels aboard the ship, they have cut inside! All Horde units be aware of hostile mech!"

The transmission cut out and Flogg's eyes widened as he saw lights flare on the frigate. Escape pods launched, followed by drifting debris as, from the obscured side of the crippled ship chunks of hull and decking began to drift out. A sizeable segment shot out and he targeted it, firing on instinct. The round sent the large chunk spinning, revealing empty space behind it.

Another chunk zipped out, dropping down and away, he tracked it but didn't fire. Then another. And another. He smirked: decoys. But he was no green recruit. He laser-painted the targets into his computer, watching their slow drift. Not like the target could make use of them except to escape, to get distance. And it wouldn't be enough, not with his weaponry.

A spark from the frigate drew his gaze and his eyes widened as the thing buckled, then ruptured as the reactor went critical. The machine split in two, more debris fountaining out, some towards him. His eyes flicked about then narrowed.

Some of the debris seemed to be accelerating towards him. Directly. He lined up his shot, cycling targets, then fired. A chunk spun away revealing… nothing. The next one did likewise. His brow furrowed again in confusion until he looked at the drifting segments from earlier. He cursed, bringing his saved targets up, his rifle pinging between them the hull plates sparking as his rounds found them.

Nothing.

Flogg snarled as he switched to more active scanning, trying to zoom in on the debris cloud. His eyes bulged and he swore as a voice crackled over his communication channel, *"Got you, asshole."*

There, in the hollowed out wreck of the ship, he saw the mech, clinging to the still drifting wreckage with one metal hand. The other clutched the torn-out cannon from the corvette. A cannon that seemed to still be working.

Flogg swore as he had to move on the defensive. The fire from the cannon speared across the void. The enemy ship had him tagged now, and due to his active scan had a read of his energy signature. He spun, flying backwards, trying to get an angle as he jinked and drifted, but the enemy mech was accelerating towards him, its purloined heavy cannon firing in bursts as it used the drifting debris as additional cover Even when it broke sight he didn't have the time to try to slip into a more passive mode to hide, as the ship popped out at odd angles.

He fired anyway, switching to his disruptor rounds. But they seemed to do little more than annoy the ship. It was fast, as fast as him, but was more agile as it ducked and moved around the wreckage.

He needed to get clear, get range and deny it the advantage of cover. Except the damn thing decided to bring it along.

He fired again and cursed as the mecha gracefully rolled around his shot, then plucked a drifting hull fragment, then another, holding them up like a pair of gauntlet shields. A round dented one, another sparked off the other. With horror he watched the ship spin, then toss one of the armour sheets like a deadly disc. It forced him to angle the mech into a dive and he lost sight.

A clang and a shake indicated the *second* piece of debris had followed the first, angled to clearly intercept him. Ironic, given he'd been doing that to this mysterious pilot.

His view was suddenly filled with the enemy as the enemy mech closed in. His railgun came up, only to be grabbed by this strange mech. A flash of blue and his weapon was split in two. He roared in rage, activating the micro-rockets built into his mech's shoulder-pauldrons. The enemy mech's hand bent his mech back and the rockets spiralled out into space, detonating harmlessly from one launcher, while the others exploded *inside* the launcher as the mech's other hand clamped down and crushed the pauldron back down. Blue energy flared and he knew that there was *some* damage to his opponent. That was scant relief, as the detonations rattled him around inside the cockpit, his head bouncing off the sides while his controls sparked. His ears rang, but the cockpit was remarkably mostly intact, the armour having held.

Atmosphere was leaking, however and he scrambled to try to get his mech's arms to get a grip on the enemy.

The spindly, claw like fingers flexed, but only one arm was really responding. The industrial mecha drifted back and caught his clumsy swipe. He watched with horror as the other mech grabbed his mech again with its free hand and planted its feet against him. With a tug he watched the foe tear his mech's arm clear off, before discarding it.

He tried to key comms, tried to radio for help. Then he tried to yield, flicking his comms to an open channel, "I surrender! I surr-"

His comms clicked off, his radio going dark, save for a single, cold artificial voice that spoke briefly, *"No failures allowed. Experiment terminated."*

Red electricity coursed through the mech. Flogg screamed as the cockpit vented and filled with sparking energy. The enemy mecha blasted away as the sniper-mech shuddered, red electricity flashing across its surface moments before it detonated in a flash of plasma and lighting.

—----------

Adora watched in horror as the enemy self-destructed.

No, it hadn’t *self-destructed* . It had been denied. She felt a twinge for the pilot. He’d been a warrior, a professional. Clearly skilled. And he’d been sacrificed merely for failing. No honour. No memory.

Her melancholy was curtailed as Tara’s voice came over her channels, “ *Blondie. You still alive?”*

“Yeah. It got.. .serious.”

“Well, no rest for the wicked. Seems your friend with the fur is set to cause a ruckus with our supply run. Feel like doing more distracting? My team is pretty dinged up.”

Adora’s heart thudded, suddenly weirdly excited. She huffed a chuckle, “Well, in for a galactic credit, in for a solid bar of gas-giant gold.”

“ *Yeah, I thought so. We’ve got inbound to scoop up those horde escape pods. I have a feeling the Empire won’t be rapid on a rescue mission, right?”*

With a moment to peruse the scene Adora grunted an agreement before she spun *Swiftwind* in the direction of the system’s edge, spooling up his odd energy to make all haste. She didn’t want to let anyone down. And she had some more points to prove.

Only to herself of course. Not to anyone else. No one at all.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you all enjoyed!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Catra goes in with a plan.

But she's up against Bow...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Coming out of sub-light ma'am."

Catra looked up from her tablet and nodded slowly as the crew bustled around the bridge, "Report?"

As they'd approached they'd had limited insight on both their target locations. The first, the attack by Adora, had seemingly gone mad. With all horde transmissions cutting out at the twenty three minute mark. Interestingly, Hordak had not responded to messages and seemed to be actively ignoring her. Catra took a dark satisfaction in that. What was more worrying was how the Horde transmissions hadn't been cut off due to some sort of clear action - they'd just *stopped* . It was like a communications black hole and Weaver seemed smug in claiming there were no *issues.*

However, all that had been erased as, while they were en route, the convoy escorts had announced they were being engaged by pirates. They didn't seem overly concerned, more a taciturn message from their group leader to say " *Bandits, moving to intercept."*

However, Catra wasn't anyone's fool. Which was why she had the Destroyer's fighter and drone compliment on standby to launch as soon as they emerged from warp. Adora's attack felt too timely. She'd briefly considered warning Hordak but she felt a little resentful. And Weaver hadn't drawn the connection it seemed. In fact the AI seemed entirely occupied elsewhere. And that suited Catra just fine.

She focused on the sensor officer turn in their chair, "Approximately five frigate vessels and six corvette weight class. Some shuttlecraft as well. The threat level is minimal - they look like freighters, ma'am. Weapons profiles seem minimal."

A subdued chuckle echoed around the bridge crew, clearly nervy but confident. Catra leaned back and saw the data scrolling past on the screen built into the command chair. She felt herself relax a little, but not much. Clearly Adora *had* hoped to pull the focus of most of the fleet, given the paltry effort and ships being deployed. She glanced at the helm, "Range to targets?"

"We're at one hundred kliks. Couldn't drop us in closer without impacting the convoy."

"Advance to optimal range and target the frigate. Order our escort frigates to move to the flank so they can't flee. Guess we need to teach these pirates a lesson. Once the *Vengeance* is in range, launch the fighter compliment - see if we can't shoot them down and capture some."

Catra's voice came out cocksure and brash, but she felt a twist in her gut. These were enemies of the state. She had given them a chance to flee and here they were, scrambling, *fighting* . They could have run. They *should* have run. She swallowed hard and kept her expression stoic, but she saw Scorpia shift uncomfortably next to her.

"Um, Wil- Commodore?"

Catra turned her gaze to her XO, trying to keep it flat and emotionless, "Commander?"

The Scorponi woman winced and glanced at the viewscreen, which showed the skirmish, "Uh, I mean…"

"Do you have a tactical observation?" Catra asked, quietly, "Or are you going to say something *really* dumb?"

That drew a low sigh from the Commander, "No, ma'am. Just wondering if we should commit so much force. They're civilians…"

"They ceased being civilians once they targeted military assets with the intent to do harm. They're *pirates* . And they do hold numerical superiority over the cargo fleet."

Scorpia lowered her voice, "But we could… chase them off? I mean, this is really unfair. They don't stand a chance."

Catra swallowed again and shrugged, "We let them run once and they just have turned around and bitten the hand. They can surrender of course. But right now, they are *combatants* . So, let's treat them like it. I appreciate you being a voice of *reason* , Scorpia. But don't push it. Now, any other actions we should take? They have a small *fleet* here. Hardly a crew of desperate civilians. They are a threat."

The Scorponi woman nodded brusquely and straightened, before casting her gaze around the bridge, "Ahead full, bring the main cannon online, target the frigate. Comms, transmit the order for the enemy to stand down and prepare for boarding. Give them one chance to submit to the Horde's clemency. Prioritise the corvettes."

"Aye ma'am!" came the chorus of voices. Scorpia huffed and nodded curtly to herself. Catra returned her gaze to her tablet and tried to ignore the sense of restlessness that washed over her.

—----------

Bow grunted as Sea Hawk adjusted himself in the cramped accessway. He shot the man a disgruntled look and tutted, "You don't need to be this close."

"Maybe not, but did you *see* the ricochet! Had to shut the hatch. Not exactly a cruise liner in here, but better than risking being in the open."

Bow hummed and nodded, eyes glued to the screen in front of him, his tracker-pad hooked into the electronic brain of the cargo-hauler. He couldn't exactly disagree with the man and sighed. He squinted and let out a sigh of relief as another of the icons on his list pinged green. Of the twelve ships, he'd managed to suborn nine, or at least gained access to their systems. Now he was just inputting a series of co-ordinates for them to short-range jump to. He also managed to access the manifests and was reading through them with a side window on his screen as his various auto-scripts ran.

Sea Hawk shifted again and glanced over Bow's shoulder to let out a low whistle, "Munitions. And… drones?"

Bow grinned, hands flying over the keyboard, "Yeah… not a bad haul. But there's four of the freighters packed to the gills with food. MREs mostly, but some fresh stuff too, plus one has a whole cargo full of water. That'll help a *lot* ."

"Good. Mer is on the side comm, sounds like the Horde is managing to keep the shuttles off their corvettes," Sea Hawk, "We've knocked down some of their drones but they seem to be…." he trailed off and groaned.

"What?"

"It's a delaying action. They're expecting reinforcements. Rather than committing and going for our ships, they're keeping our

shuttles locked in a dogfight *inside* the cargo formation. The *CADS!* "

Bow hissed in frustration and his eyes widened. The hauler's sensors pinged a very large blob on its sensors, ahead of the convoy, "I think they're here. We've only been at this what.. Half an hour? They can't have responded that fast."

Sea Hawk shook his head hurriedly, "Must be a surprise inspection. Drat. Is it a frigate?"

"It's the Destroyer. The *Vengeance.* " Bow's eyes narrowed, "And it looks like it's moving straight for Mermista's fleet. I count three Frigates as escorts. No fighter screen yet."

Sea Hawk shook his fist and cursed, "By the crushing waves of the deepest black holes, what the hell… we need a plan. Something! Without the *Seagate* we can't match them," his expression became grim, "We need Mermista to flee. To preserve the fleet. To live to avenge us."

Bow turned wide eyes on Sea Hawk, "What? No! My wife would kill me if I get killed!"

"Better the death of an adventurer than to be captured!"

"What, like you were?" Bow deadpanned.

“That was… entirely different! I intended to die! Heroically!” Sea Hawk winced, “And yes, Mermista has boxed my ears about that.”

“So, my point stands,” Bow looked at his pad and blinked. Then his gaze narrowed, “So, that thing about drone controls,” he smiled thinly as Sea Hawk fixed his gaze on him, “Can you get Mermista to move the fleet *into* the convoy formation? We’ll need cover.”

Sea Hawk blinked then tilted his head slowly, a grin visible through the faceplate of his mask, “Oh. Ohhhhh. I think I like what your thoughts and thinking, my mechanically minded matey!” he keyed his comm, including Bow in the transmission, “Darling, oh dream, oh…”

“Keep the channel clear, dumbass. We’re in a firefight and we have a stars-damned CAPITAL SHIP bearing down on us! I don’t have time to flirt. You need to exfil so we can bug out.”

Mermista’s voice was clearly cracked with frustration and disappointment. To be chased off by the same ship that had wiped out *her* flagship. Sea Hawk took a breath, “Negative, Captain. But we have a plan. Move the fleet into the cargo convoy. Bow is going to clump them up. We have a plan.”

“That’s insane. Move closer *to the ship with the gigantic rail-laser beam weapon thing?!”*

“Trust me.”

There was a very long pause before the comm echoed with a gusty sigh and Mermista growled and final *“Fine* .” Then the line went dead. Sea Hawk stared and Bow and nodded.

“Win or lose. Live or die. What an adventure today has been!”

—----------

“Ma’am, Convoy escorts are reporting issues.”

Catra frowned as she leaned forwards, elbows on her knees. She squinted at the holographic display in the centre of the bridge, then tilted her head. The convoy seemed to be slowing, clumping up. The enemy “frigates” had moved ahead, as if intending to meet the Horde, but then had moved to almost join the convoy, using some of the haulers as cover. This denied her a clear shot with the main gun. She grimaced and shook her head.

“Clever, we’ll have to close. This is going to be a knife fight then.”

“Ma’am?” the sensor officer echoed the tactical ensign and turned a frown to her. She returned his gaze and gestured for him to

explain, “The escort team have lost control of some of their drones. Potential jammers deployed?”

“Active contact, one of the corvettes has reported extensive damage to their engines!” the tactical officer announced. On the screen, one of the green dots blipped with amber rings, “They’re in a spin, total loss of control.”

“Those ‘ *frigates’* packing more of a punch?” Scorpia asked.

“Negative, ma’am. One of the fighters is down. And another… damn, their drones are engaging them!” the tactical officer seemed shocked, “Second corvette experiencing effective fire from the frigates. Their shuttles are focusing on the escort fighters, and the drone screen is completely gone. We’ve lost… one… two…”

The convoy escort was on the main screen, a collection of icons. The corvettes were amber, one slowly turning red as it took fire, indicating damage, half the fighters were red, to show destroyed, or green. And the half dozen fighters seemed to have gone to two. Catra twitched.

“Time to range?”

“Thirty seconds, ma’am!”

“Firing solutions?”

Scorpia moved to the weapon station, “No effective visual without hitting a cargo vessel.”

“Order our escorts to flush them out. If we can ID the command ship and take that out, the rest will flee or surrender. They’re souped up freighters for Star’s sake.”

The seconds ticked by as they closed. She felt the destroyer vibrate as various heavy turrets turned to prepare to fire. On the view screen she could see her own ship’s escorts pulling ahead, ready to attack, moving to above and below the enemy fleet, to split their fire. A confused gasp from the sensor station made her turn.

“Ma’am, one of the cargo drones has split from the fleet and is on an *intercept* course for our lead frigate.”

Catra blinked and her eyes widened, “Destroy it!”

The *Vengeance* lurched as orders echoed across the bridge and they adjusted course, ready to bring the main gun to bear. The frigate ahead tried to adjust course. As the *Vengeance* charged its main gun, the Hauler adjusted course, aiming for the destroyer. Catra frowned, then her eyes bugged as the hauler ejected its cargo pods. They detached, then seemed to expand as they *opened* , drifting through space. The cargo containers continued ahead, carried by momentum, along with the suddenly expanding

cloud of the container contents: construction material, fuel cells, metallic fragments and what seemed to be *munitions* .

The cloud spread out in an expanding cone. The helmsman cursed as he adjusted course, intending to dip down, to try to minimise the impact, while shouting *"BRACE!"*

The hull clanged and squealed as fast-moving debris slammed against the reinforced plate. Alarms blared as the heavy cargo containers smashed and scraped along the surface of the destroyer, sending sparks into the void. A deep *clunk* sounded as one hit and clearly jammed into the hull itself.

"Breach! We're sealing compartments," came a shout from the engineering terminal. The screen lit up with flashes as several of the fuel cells drifting in space hit the hull and vapourised violently. The plasma burned even in space, scoring the hull and melting through in small patches. Catra swore and gestured at tactical, "Point defence? Heard of it?"

"Aye aye! Moving to manual!"

She could hear the rattle as the hull vibrated, the smaller autoguns firing into the debris cloud, which they were now just clearing. The heavy guns boomed, wiping out the cargo hauler as it tried to close the distance. The thing was blasted off course, missing them by a wide margin as it tumbled through space.

Scorpia grimaced and turned to look at Catra, “Commodore, frigate *Pike* is reporting effective fire! The enemy has moved to engage them. Another hauler has damaged frigate *Halberd* . Frigate *Windblade* is moving to support *Pike* .”

“Get us into the fight, helm.”

“Ma’am, some of the haulers are adjusting, moving to jump to sub-light, I’m reading energy buildups,” Catra blinked *again* . Another shout of surprise caught her attention as the Sensor ensign stared at her console, “One of the haulers has launched… drones?”

Catra swallowed and shook her head, “How many?”

“...I count a hundred. They’re not moving with any clear combat formation, just swarming. They’re closing on the *Pike* .”

Scorpia shook her head and turned to comms, “See if you can’t trace the sensor signal. They have a hacker. Someone’s using frequencies to override the drones. ID it and jam it!”

“ *Pike* reporting multiple impacts *Windblade* is pulling back, reporting the enemy are switching to fire on them. Remaining cargo haulers are moving to act as shields.”

Catra glowered, “Target the enemy frigates, fire at will, ignore the cargo haulers. We can salvage the cargo.”

“Second hauler inbound towards us ma’am, it’s the drone hauler!” reported the sensor ensign. The Commodore swore.

“Take it out, give me firing solutions!”

On screen, she saw one of her frigates detonate in a fireball as multiple drones slammed into it, acting as dumb missiles. Clearly the damn things hadn’t been equipped with weapons while in transit, but they still weighed a tonne *and* had reactors and fuel cells. She saw the swarm move and bee-line for the destroyer. Ahead, the cargo hauler began to fragment under the withering fire of the destroyer, but it was bearing on a direct intercept course. It’d likely hit.

Beyond it, she saw the enemy frigates wink out as they jumped to sub-light, joined by several of the cargo-haulers, all moving on different trajectories.

The two remaining Horde frigates fired upon the incoming cargo hauler, succeeding only in knocking its cargo pods onto new trajectories away from the destroyer. Catra stared as the hauler bore down, about to impale her flagship, a burning spindle of metal and mindless momentum, which seemed to be inevitably driving towards them event as the heavy guns of her ship blasted into it. There was no chance it'd be blasted apart without a hefty part of it slamming into them and likely causing catastrophic damage.

A shriek of blue energy exploded in front of the frigate as something dropped out of sub-light. The sheer wake of energy that washed across the ships sent sensors wobbling and all the bridge screens haywire with distortion. Afterimages played across the sensor and visual screens, like a timelapse, as a mecha stopped just off the bow of the incoming hauler. It moved fast, slamming into the hauler and shunting the thing off course, sending the spindle-like hauler corkscrewing on a new trajectory. Catra watched, wide eyed, as the hauler passed within inches of the destroyer, a disaster narrowly averted.

The crew were silent as they stared at the screens and the view-screen that showed the glowing blue ship in the void before them. Energy pulsed off it in waves. Then the mecha gave a jaunty salute and blasted towards the destroyer, flashing over the bridge in a split second before it blipped out of range with another short jump.

Catra slumped back in her command chair as red lights flashed and sirens blared. She shook her head then facepalmed as a sense of deja vu hit her *hard.*

"Crap."

—----------

The crowd in the hangar of the rebel base was jubilant. Bow staggered from the shuttle he and Sea Hawk had been collected

by and straightened with a stretch. He was almost bowled over by a jubilant and bouncy pink-haired bartended. Glimmer smothered him with kisses, then pulled back to glare at him, "You manually hijacked a Horde ship and then sent them on *kamikaze* runs? What were you thinking?"

"That I wanted to see your shining face again?" Bow tried with a grin. He waggled his eyebrows and Glimmer rolled her eyes, then shoved him.

"Goof."

"Yeah. But you're happy to see me, right?" He smiled at her, then arched a brow. Glimmer huffed and smiled, then pulled him in for a hug.

Sea Hawk stood next to them, arms open wide as Mermista shoved her way through the throng. She glared at him, then yanked him towards her, before she dipped him and planted a huge kiss on his lips. A cheer rose from the pirates and rebels around her, along with a few laughs.

The voices quietened as a shuttle coasted into the crowded hanger. Visible in the void beyond were a few civilian haulers towing in the salvaged cargo pods from the Horde transports. The transports themselves had been left, drifting in the void, well away from the base, having just been stripped of their cargo and a few vital computer systems.

The crowd watched as the shuttle, a bulky industrial hauler-mech type, settled down. The hatch on its side hissed open and Adora emerged, ready to jump down. She froze, suddenly aware of all the faces watching her. Then a voice piped up from the crowd, as Tara shoved her way through, punching a fist into the air:

"She-Raider! She-Raider!"

The chant echoed as the crowd picked it up, Mermista yelling from the front, echoed by Bow, Glimmer and Sea Hawk. Adora blushed, then waved at the crowd, which just cheered. She hopped down and found herself getting back slaps and shoulder shakes from ecstatic crew and rebels alike. She made it to her friends and grinned at Bow, dumbfounded, "I don't know why they're cheering me. According to what Mermista said en route back, it was all you, Bow."

"Ahh, you can have the limelight now," Bow grinned, buffing his fingernails on his overalls in a show of mock-arrogance, "I am a hero, y'know."

"Goof," chided Glimmer, before she looked at Adora, "We heard what you did out there. And this is just… we *know* what you've done. Just everyone else is beginning to see it. And the fact you were busting yourself to rescue everyone else, even though they didn't need it? Well, extra points."

"Yeah, like, it was…. Good. And whatever, but appreciated. You made this happen. Who knows what'd have happened if that mech had taken us on? We'd have been vapourised. You're cool, Adora," drawled Mermista. She had her arm slung over Sea

Hawk's shoulders and the man looked practically drunk with joy. Adora let out a sigh and nodded.

"Thanks guys. But I think there's maybe one more thing to focus on."

"Oh yeah?" Bow frowned, "What's that?"

"Someone mentioned… a party?" Adora grinned hopefully, her face clearly nervous. A heavy hand clamped onto her shoulder and Tara loomed next to her.

"Blondie's got a point. Let's get this started! Our first battle in the fightback against the Horde!"

That drew another cheer from around them and the group headed back towards the impromptu base set in the ruins of the planetoid fragment. Adora paused and looked back at *Swift Wind* , shooting the ship a thumbs up and a smile, before she turned back to follow her comrades.

No. not comrades.

Her friends.

For the first time in a long while, she walked with a lightness in her step. The Horde would throw who knew what at them, but she knew she could face it. But for now she didn’t feel the need to worry, to panic, to fret.

She didn’t have to face the darkness alone. And maybe, just maybe, she could save someone else.

Chapter End Notes

A bit of a lighthearted one this time, laying the groundwork for the future. Catra's riding high, but where will she go from here?

Adora is on a better path it would seem.

So... wonder what could possibly go wrong. Stay tuned for the next exciting episode of...

SPACE!

(To be continued)

CAPTAIN!

CATRA!

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